

The Physiotherapy Enquiry Checklist

Eight questions that turn “do you take my insurance?” into a ready-to-book assessment, how to handle referral and pre-approval questions without promising cover, the red-flag symptoms that must go straight to a person, and a weekly scorecard. Everything here works with the free WhatsApp Business app.

1. Why the first reply matters

Physiotherapy enquiries often come from people in pain, messaging in the evening or after a GP visit, and many contact more than one clinic. In Harvard Business Review's study of online sales leads, firms that contacted a lead within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify it as firms that waited longer.

Source: J. Oldroyd, K. McElheran, D. Elkington, “The Short Life of Online Sales Leads”, Harvard Business Review, March 2011 — hbr.org/2011/03/the-short-life-of-online-sales-leads

2. The 8-question intake

Ask these in the first reply. They give your front desk what it needs to book the right physiotherapist and start any insurance approval.

#	Ask	Why it matters
1	What is the problem, and where? (back, neck, knee, shoulder, sports injury, after surgery, other)	Routes to the right physiotherapist and session length.
2	Any numbness or weakness in both legs, changes in bladder or bowel control, chest pain, or did it start after a serious accident?	Goes to a person immediately (section 4).
3	Insurance or self-pay? If insurance: which insurer and plan, as shown on the card	Network and plan decide whether a referral and pre-approval are needed.
4	Do you have a doctor's referral or prescription? (photo or PDF is fine)	Most insurers ask for one before covered sessions start (section 3).
5	After surgery? Which operation, and roughly when	Post-operative patients usually need the surgeon's protocol and a longer first session.
6	Clinic or home visit; preferred branch; two days or times that suit you	One confirmation message instead of three.
7	Physiotherapist gender preference, if any	Common request; avoids a rebooking.
8	Name, and preferred language: English or Arabic	Assign the right staff member for the call-back.

Copy-paste intake message (WhatsApp)

Thank you for contacting [Clinic]! To book your assessment, please send: 1) the problem and where it hurts, 2) whether it is after surgery, 3) insurance (insurer and plan) or self-pay, 4) a photo of your doctor's referral if you have one, 5) clinic or home visit and two days/times that suit you, 6) any therapist preference, 7) your name. Our team will confirm by [time]. If you have numbness or weakness in both legs, loss of bladder or bowel control, chest pain, or the pain started after a serious accident, please call 998 or go to the nearest emergency department now.

3. Answering “Is it covered?” without promising cover

The most common first question is about insurance. Only the insurer can confirm cover, so replies should collect what is needed and set expectations honestly.

Question	Safe reply pattern	Why
“Do you accept my insurance?”	Say which insurers the clinic is in network with (from your approved list) and that cover depends on the plan; ask for the insurer and plan name.	Outpatient physiotherapy is generally reimbursed only at approved network clinics.

Question	Safe reply pattern	Why
"Do I need a referral?"	For insurance, usually yes: a physician's referral or prescription with the diagnosis. Self-pay patients can book an assessment directly if your clinic allows it.	Dubai clinics report that most insurers require a referral; Essential Benefits Plan members typically see a GP first.
"Can I start tomorrow?"	Yes as self-pay; for insurance, the clinic requests pre-approval first and confirms once it is received.	Pre-approval is usually needed before the first covered session; retroactive approval is rarely granted. One Dubai clinic reports 24–72 hours as typical.
"How many sessions will I get?"	The insurer sets the number per plan and per approval; the physiotherapist will advise on a plan after assessment.	Session caps and co-payments vary widely by plan — don't quote a number in chat.
"How much without insurance?"	Quote only the clinic's current published prices.	Avoids disputes and unapproved discounts.

Sources: Physiocure Dubai, "Physiotherapy and Insurance in Dubai" (physiocuredubai.com/blog/physiotherapy-health-insurance-dubai-guide/); Doctors Clinic Dubai, "Does Insurance Cover Physiotherapy in Dubai?" (doctorsclinicdubai.ae/blog/insurance-cover-physiotherapy-dubai/). These are clinic guides, not insurer rules; always check the patient's own policy. General information, not medical, insurance or legal advice.

4. Safety lines for every reply (staff or automated)

- **No diagnosis, no exercise advice in chat.** Replies give information and collect details; clinical questions go to a physiotherapist.
- **Red flags go to a person at once.** With back pain, the NHS advises emergency care for pain, tingling, weakness or numbness in both legs; loss of feeling around the genitals or anus; changes in bladder or bowel control; chest pain; or pain that started after a serious accident. Messages mentioning these — in English or Arabic — should alert staff immediately, and the reply gives 998 and the nearest emergency department rather than offering the next slot.
- **No slot is confirmed automatically** unless it comes from your real booking system, and no insurance cover is ever confirmed in chat.
- **Referral letters and reports are health data.** Under UAE Federal Law No. 2 of 2019, Article 13, health information may not be stored, processed or transferred outside the UAE except as set by the health authorities. Ask any chat or AI vendor where messages and attachments are stored.

Sources: NHS, "Back pain" (nhs.uk/conditions/back-pain/); Federal Law No. 2 of 2019 (uaelegislation.gov.ae). General information, not medical or legal advice.

5. Weekly scorecard (10 minutes every Monday)

Number	How to count it
Enquiries received	New WhatsApp / Instagram DM / web-form enquiries this week
Median first-reply time	Middle value of time from first message to first human or assistant reply
Replied within 1 hour	% of enquiries answered within 60 minutes, including evenings and weekends
Complete requests	% with problem, insurance or self-pay, referral status and preferred time after the first exchange
Pre-approvals requested	Insurance cases sent for approval, and median time to a decision
Assessments booked	Enquiries that became a booked first assessment
Red flags escalated	Messages handed to staff for urgent symptoms, and how fast

6. Want to see this working on your own enquiries?

Try our sample assistant for a fictional physiotherapy clinic:

mountainai-ae.com/demo/physiotherapy-clinic-assistant.html. It asks the questions above in English or Arabic, never diagnoses or confirms insurance cover, and hands anything urgent to a person.

Free demo in 24 hours, built from your clinic's public website, private link. → **14-day pilot AED 1,500**, live on your WhatsApp Business number or website, credited in full if you continue. → **Full setup AED 7,500 + AED 1,250/month** (hosting, monitoring, monthly updates; Meta WhatsApp fees billed to you directly). We don't promise a number of bookings — the pilot report shows what actually happened.

Reply **DEMO** on WhatsApp +971 56 777 3366 or email info@mountainai-ae.com.